

HOMICIDE DIVISION • CONFIDENTIAL CASE FILE

CASE 1

THE VANISHING AT SECTOR 7

A locked-room murder investigation at Aether Biometrix Sector 7 cleanroom.

Victim	Dr. Aris Thorne, Senior Researcher
Location	Sector 7 Class-1 Cleanroom, Aether Biometrix
Reported	6:00 AM, Overnight Security
Lead Investigator	Detective (Player Character)
Assisting Officer	Officer Miller

Case Synopsis

Dr. Aris Thorne was found dead inside Sector 7, a sealed Class-1 cleanroom at Aether Biometrix, at 6:00 AM. Security logs confirm the airtight magnetic doors were locked from 2:00 AM until discovery, and the room's cameras blacked out for exactly 90 seconds at 3:14 AM. No physical door seal was ever tripped. This file documents the full investigation, from crime scene processing through interrogation and formal indictment.

ID	Evidence	Source
E1	Body Position Clue (lividity pattern)	Examine the body
E2	Conveyor Belt Clue (torn cloth, scuffing)	Inspect conveyor hatch
E3	Blue Chemical Stain (Fluorinert coolant)	UV scan — Elena Cruz
E4	Smartwatch Log (Bluetooth pairing, 3:14 AM)	Server audit log
E5	Threatening Email (Thorne → Vance, 1:15 AM)	Vance's laptop / archive
E6	Heat Sterilizer Log (65°C decon cycle)	Server audit log

Verification threshold: at least 4 of the 6 clues above must be collected before an indictment can proceed.

SCENE 1

Arrival & Crime Scene Briefing

Background: *bg_cleanroom_int.png* | Default Active Sprite: *officer_miller_neutral.png*

Part 1 — Briefing Dialogue

OFFICER MILLER

"Thanks for getting here fast, Detective. The facility called it in at 6:00 AM."

DETECTIVE

"Give me the basics, Miller. What are we looking at?"

OFFICER MILLER

"That's Dr. Aris Thorne inside. Senior researcher here at Aether Biometrix. He was discovered slumped in his chair inside Sector 7. The overnight security team assumed sudden cardiac arrest."

DETECTIVE

"If it's just a medical event, why pull homicide out here?"

OFFICER MILLER

"Because Sector 7 is a Class-1 airtight cleanroom. The magnetic pressure doors only open with master authorization badges. Security logs show the airlock was fully locked from 2:00 AM until morning. Nobody entered. Nobody left."

DETECTIVE

"A locked-room scenario. What about surveillance?"

OFFICER MILLER

"Every camera inside Sector 7 glitched out for exactly 90 seconds around 3:14 AM. Yet the physical door seals never tripped."

DETECTIVE

"Then someone found a blind spot. Stand by the door, Miller. I'm going to inspect the room."

Part 2 — Crime Scene Investigation Choices

Scene 1 — Choose an Action

1A — Examine Dr. Thorne's body — kneel beside the chair with a forensic UV torch

→ Clue E1 acquired +10 Energy

1B — Inspect the conveyor wall hatch — check the small materials pass-through tunnel

→ Clue E2 acquired +10 Energy

1C — Kick the reinforced airlock door — attempt to force the electromagnetic seal

→ No clue found -20 Energy

Choice 1A — Examine Dr. Thorne's Body

Active Sprite: *thorne_deceased.png*

(Snaps on nitrile gloves and kneels beside the chair)

DETECTIVE

"Let's see what you're hiding, Doctor..."

(Detective turns on the forensic UV torch and unzips the collar of the cleanroom suit)

DETECTIVE

"Miller, take a look at the purple skin discoloration along his shoulder blades and spine."

OFFICER MILLER

"Isn't that typical post-mortem pooling?"

DETECTIVE

"Only if he died lying down. When circulation stops, gravity pulls blood to the lowest points. If he suffered heart failure sitting upright in this chair, lividity would settle in his legs and lower abdomen. But his back is completely flat and discolored."

OFFICER MILLER

"Which means..."

DETECTIVE

"He died lying flat on the floor somewhere else. He stayed there for at least thirty minutes before someone hauled him into this chair to stage a natural death."

✓ SYSTEM NOTIFICATION

Clue Acquired: E1 (Body Position Clue) | Energy: +10 AP

Choice 1B — Inspect the Conveyor Wall Hatch

Active Sprite: *officer_miller_neutral.png*

DETECTIVE

"Miller, what is this stainless steel tunnel cut through the glass wall?"

OFFICER MILLER

"That's the materials pass-through conveyor. Techs use it to slide silicon wafer trays inside without cycling the human airlock."

DETECTIVE

"Is it motorized?"

OFFICER MILLER

"Motorized rubber belt. Press a button outside, and it rolls supplies through."

(Kneels down with a flashlight, checking the drive gears)

DETECTIVE

"Look at the rubber rollers. Scuff marks, heavy torque strain... and caught in the teeth right here is a scrap of white synthetic cloth."

OFFICER MILLER

"A torn lab coat?"

DETECTIVE

"Exactly. And there are fresh rub marks along the steel frame, roughly shoulder-width. Someone pushed a heavy body through this opening."

✓ SYSTEM NOTIFICATION

Clue Acquired: E2 (Conveyor Belt Clue) | Energy: +10 AP

Choice 1C — Try Forcing Open the Emergency Exit Door

Active Sprite: officer_miller_serious.png

(Detective kicks the frame and wrenches the steel handle)

DETECTIVE

"Let me check if this secondary door seal has give."

OFFICER MILLER

"Careful, Detective! That's a 500-pound electromagnetic door. You'll dislocate a shoulder before that latch gives."

DETECTIVE

"Damn it. Not even a millimeter of play. Wasted time."

✗ SYSTEM NOTIFICATION

No Clue Found! | Energy: -20 AP

SCENE 2

Sub-Level Security & Chemical Testing Bay

Part 1 — Encountering Kevin Lin at the Console

Background: bg_security_hub.png | Active Sprite: kevin_neutral.png

DETECTIVE

"Kevin Lin? Senior firmware engineer?"

(Adjusts his wire-frame glasses rapidly)

KEVIN LIN

"Y-yes! Hi. Officer Miller told me you needed to review the server event logs?"

DETECTIVE

"You seem on edge, Kevin. Rough shift?"

KEVIN LIN

"Just... shaken up. Dr. Thorne was brilliant. A bit short-tempered with software bugs, sure, but nobody deserved this."

DETECTIVE

"Where were you between 2:00 AM and 4:00 AM?"

KEVIN LIN

"Asleep! In the second-floor staff on-call bunk room. My shift ended at 1:00 AM sharp. I powered off my phone and slept until the alarms sounded at 6:00 AM."

DETECTIVE

"And the cameras blacking out for 90 seconds at 3:14 AM? How does an automated CCTV system crash on cue?"

KEVIN LIN

"Hardware fluctuation! Old coaxial lines, probably. Or a power dip from the cleanroom compressor pumps. I've logged repair requests for months!"

Choice 2A — Inspect the Server Terminal Manually

Active Sprite: kevin_nervous.png

DETECTIVE

"Step aside, Kevin. Let's see what the audit log says."

(Swallows hard, backing away from the console)

KEVIN LIN

"Go ahead... it's just raw command lines, though."

(Keystrokes click rapidly)

DETECTIVE

"The blackout wasn't a power dip. A script named `bypass_loop.sh` executed at 03:14:10 AM. And right as it ran, a local Bluetooth peripheral paired with the terminal."

KEVIN LIN

"B-Bluetooth? Anyone in the building could carry a phone!"

DETECTIVE

"The MAC address matches a wearable smart tracker. And look at 03:16 AM — someone activated Sector 7's thermal sterilizer, ramping room temperature to 65°C."

KEVIN LIN

"The heat cycle? That's strictly for decontamination between production runs!"

DETECTIVE

"Or for destroying contact DNA, fingerprints, and fabric fibers."

✓ SYSTEM NOTIFICATION

Clues Acquired: E4 (Smartwatch Log) & E6 (Heat Sterilizer Log) | Energy: +10 AP

Part 2 — Confronting Dr. Elena Cruz in the Lab

Background: *bg_chem_lab.png* | Active Sprite: *elena_neutral.png*

(Tapping her tablet without looking up)

DR. ELENA CRUZ

"Can I help you, Detective? I'm standardizing spectrometer reagents."

DETECTIVE

"I'm heading the inquiry into Dr. Thorne's death."

(Looks up with an icy, composed smile)

DR. ELENA CRUZ

"A tragic loss. Aris was a gifted researcher, even if his paranoia made collaboration exhausting."

DETECTIVE

"Paranoia about what?"

DR. ELENA CRUZ

"Spies. Stolen patents. Falsified data. Typical senior scientist delusions."

DETECTIVE

"When did you last see him alive?"

DR. ELENA CRUZ

"Around 2:15 AM. We argued over sensor yield benchmarks. I realized nothing productive would come of it, badged out through the main gate at 2:30 AM, and drove straight home."

DETECTIVE

"And you stayed home until morning?"

DR. ELENA CRUZ

"Of course. Verify the gate turnstile logs."

Choice 2B — UV Scan the Lab Coats in the Locker Bay

Active Sprite: *elena_defensive.png*

DETECTIVE

"Mind if I inspect the coats hung in this bay?"

(Folds arms defensively)

DR. ELENA CRUZ

"Are you suggesting I violate cleanroom sterilization protocols? Every garment here is autoclaved nightly."

(Clicks on the UV torch, panning across her locker)

DETECTIVE

"Autoclaved, perhaps. But look at the left cuff of your lab coat."

DR. ELENA CRUZ

"What of it...?"

DETECTIVE

"Bright neon-blue fluorescence. Fluorinert FC-40 coolant, used exclusively in Sector 7's heat exchange manifolds. If you left the facility at 2:30 AM and never entered the cleanroom wing, how did fresh coolant spray your sleeve?"

(Avert eyes, jaw tightening)

DR. ELENA CRUZ

"I... I must have brushed against an open solvent valve yesterday morning."

DETECTIVE

"Fluorinert evaporates in four hours under room air. This spray pattern is less than three hours old."

✓ SYSTEM NOTIFICATION

Clue Acquired: E3 (Blue Chemical Stain) | Energy: +10 AP

Choice 2C — Search Cafeteria Trash Bins

Background: bg_corridor_night.png | Active Sprite: officer_miller_neutral.png

DETECTIVE

"Maybe the killer dumped something in the staff kitchen."

(Digs through discarded cups and food wrappers)

OFFICER MILLER

"Find anything useful, Detective? Beyond half-eaten sandwiches?"

(Tosses gloves into the bin)

DETECTIVE

"Just food waste. Nothing related to the crime."

✗ SYSTEM NOTIFICATION

No Clue Found! | Energy: -20 AP

SCENE 3

The Executive Penthouse & Interrogations

Part 1 — Investigating Marcus Vance’s Suite

Background: bg_executive_office.png | Active Sprite: officer_miller_neutral.png

Choice 3A — Search Marcus Vance’s Desk and Laptop

(Examining the corner office)

DETECTIVE

"Expensive single malt, walnut furniture, skyline view. Mr. Vance lives comfortably."

OFFICER MILLER

"He claims he was stuck here all night reviewing quarterly reports."

(Opens the laptop; prompted for a 4-digit bypass PIN)

DETECTIVE

"Let’s see... Dr. Thorne’s employee ID on the cleanroom board was 9941. Let’s run it against the secondary email archive... Access confirmed."

OFFICER MILLER

"A backup archive?"

DETECTIVE

"Thorne’s unsent drafts folder. Timestamped 01:15 AM, addressed to Marcus Vance: ‘Marcus, pull the fraudulent sensor yield reports before the 8:00 AM board call, or I deliver the raw telemetry directly to federal regulators.'"

DETECTIVE

"That’s a multi-million-dollar motive. Vance wasn’t just working late; he was facing ruin."

✓ SYSTEM NOTIFICATION
Clue Acquired: E5 (Threatening Email) | Energy: +10 AP

Part 2 — The Formal Interrogations

Background: bg_interrogation_room.png

Confront Dr. Elena Cruz	Confront Kevin Lin	Confront Marcus Vance
Present: E3 — Blue Chemical Stain	Present: E4 — Smartwatch Log	Present: E5 — Threatening Email
Sprite: elena_shocked	Sprite: kevin_panicked	Sprite: vance_angry

Interrogating Dr. Elena Cruz

Active Sprite: elena_defensive.png

DETECTIVE

"Sit down, Dr. Cruz. Let's drop the corporate script."

DR. ELENA CRUZ

"I have research deadlines. Am I under arrest? If not, I am leaving."

DETECTIVE

"You're not going anywhere until you explain the fresh Fluorinert coolant on your cuff (E3)."

[PLAYER PRESENTS CLUE: E3 — Blue Chemical Stain] | Active Sprite switches to: elena_shocked.png

(Eyes widen in panic, hands gripping the metal table)

DR. ELENA CRUZ

"Where did you... how did you spot that?!"

DETECTIVE

"The science doesn't lie. You never went home at 2:30 AM."

(Buries face in trembling hands)

DR. ELENA CRUZ

"Fine! I didn't leave! I used the basement maintenance hatch to sneak back upstairs at 2:50 AM."

DETECTIVE

"To murder Aris Thorne?"

DR. ELENA CRUZ

"No! Aris carried the master sensor data on an encrypted drive in his pocket. If he blew the whistle, the entire project funding would vanish and my career would be ruined! I went to take the drive!"

DETECTIVE

"And what did you see?"

DR. ELENA CRUZ

"He was already dead! He was lying flat on his back in the corridor outside Sector 7! I took the drive from his coat and fled! I swear he was already cold!"

Interrogating Kevin Lin

Active Sprite: kevin_nervous.png

DETECTIVE

"Kevin. Take a seat."

(Wiping sweaty palms on his jeans)

KEVIN LIN

"Detective, please... I maintain network switches. I don't know anything about homicides!"

DETECTIVE

"Then explain why your smartwatch pinged the Sector 7 airlock terminal at 03:14 AM (E4), the exact second the surveillance cameras went dark."

[PLAYER PRESENTS CLUE: E4 — Smartwatch Log] | Active Sprite switches to: kevin_panicked.png

(Clutches his head, breathing rapidly)

KEVIN LIN

"Oh god... the Bluetooth handshake logged?!"

DETECTIVE

"Every packet gets logged, Kevin. Start talking before you're charged as a primary accessory to murder."

(Pleading)

KEVIN LIN

"I didn't hurt him! Yesterday afternoon, an encrypted messenger offered me \$5,000 in crypto to execute a 90-second camera test script at 03:14 AM from the hall terminal! They told me it was just a mock penetration test!"

DETECTIVE

"Did you see who was in that corridor?"

KEVIN LIN

"I hid behind the server column! When the feed cut, I peeked around the partition. I saw someone in a dark gray three-piece suit dragging a body toward the materials conveyor hatch!"

DETECTIVE

"A suit? Not a lab coat?"

KEVIN LIN

"A tailored suit! He shoved the body onto the belt, keyed the wall terminal, and took the private executive lift upstairs!"

Interrogating Marcus Vance

Active Sprite: vance_neutral.png

(Leaning back smoothly, smiling)

MARCUS VANCE

"Detective. I trust my staff has been helpful. We're all keen to resolve this unfortunate incident."

DETECTIVE

"It wasn't an incident, Mr. Vance. It was premeditated murder."

(Smirks)

MARCUS VANCE

"An entertaining theory. But theories require evidence and motive."

DETECTIVE

"Let's discuss motive. What about the draft Dr. Thorne sent to your personal terminal at 01:15 AM? (E5)"

[PLAYER PRESENTS CLUE: E5 — Threatening Email] | Active Sprite switches to: vance_angry.png

(Smile disappears; jaw clenches into a cold, venomous glare)

MARCUS VANCE

"You accessed my private company files."

DETECTIVE

"He gave you until 8:00 AM to retract the falsified data, or he would contact federal investigators. You met him in the corridor at 2:00 AM to shut him down."

(Quiet, cold voice)

MARCUS VANCE

"Aris was an unstable perfectionist. Disclosing minor calibration variances would have wiped out our stock price, cost hundreds of jobs, and destroyed decades of my work. But having a disagreement doesn't prove murder. Sector 7 was sealed from the inside. Explain how I put him in that room."

SCENE 4

Clue Verification Gate (60% Check)

Background: bg_interrogation_room.png | Active Sprite: officer_miller_serious.png

Required Evidence: ≥ 4 out of 6 clues collected

Condition A — Player Has Fewer Than 4 Clues

OFFICER MILLER

"Detective, we can't indict the CEO of a multi-billion-dollar tech firm on incomplete hunches! The prosecutor will dismiss this instantly. We need harder proof. Head back to the lab and check the logs again."

Condition B — Player Has 4 or More Clues

DETECTIVE

"I have the physical evidence, the timeline, the transfer method, and the financial motive. Miller, prep the warrants."

SCENE 5

The Final Accusation & Case Resolution

Background: *bg_interrogation_room.png* | Active Sprite: *vance_angry.png*

Indictment Decision — Break the Case

Question 1: Who murdered Dr. Aris Thorne?

[A] Dr. Elena Cruz — Incorrect (only stole the patent USB drive)

[B] Kevin Lin — Incorrect (only disabled cameras for a bribe)

[C] **Marcus Vance** ← **CORRECT**

Question 2: How did the body enter the locked room?

[A] The killer entered through the ceiling ventilation duct.

[B] **Vance suffocated Thorne in the corridor, fed the body through the motorized materials conveyor during the 90-second camera blackout, and triggered the 65°C heat cycle to destroy touch DNA.** ← **CORRECT**

[C] Dr. Thorne swallowed poison inside the sealed cleanroom.

Resolution & Confession

Active Sprite switches to: *vance_defeated.png*

DETECTIVE

"Here is the exact chain of events, Vance:"

At 2:15 AM, you confronted Aris in the corridor outside Sector 7. When he refused your buyout, you asphyxiated him. That is why his blood settled flat across his spine **(E1)**.

At 2:50 AM, Dr. Cruz discovered the body, panicked, and stole his patent flash drive, picking up fresh coolant on her sleeve **(E3)**.

At 3:14 AM, you capitalized on Kevin's paid camera blackout **(E4)**. You pushed Thorne's body onto the motorized materials intake conveyor **(E2)**, feeding him inside without tripping the sealed airlock!

You reached through, positioned him upright in the lab chair, and triggered the 65°C thermal sterilizer from the corridor console **(E6)** to vaporize every trace of touch DNA and fabric fibers!

(Tie loosened, hands trembling, staring down in bitter fury)

MARCUS VANCE

"He was going to burn this company to the ground over a rounding error! Over numbers on a spreadsheet! I built this empire... I wasn't going to let an academic ruin it!"

(Steps in with handcuffs, placing them on Vance's wrists)

OFFICER MILLER

"Marcus Vance, you are under arrest for first-degree murder. You have the right to remain silent..."

STATUS: CASE SOLVED

RATING — S-RANK: MASTER FORENSIC DETECTIVE

All forensic contradictions resolved. Chain of custody verified. Indictment secured.